

A scanning electron micrograph showing a dense cluster of intestinal villi. These are finger-like projections with a highly textured, ridged surface. The lighting is warm, highlighting the three-dimensional structure of the villi.

VILLI

The inside of the small intestine is lined with tiny fingerlike projections called villi, which are about 0.04 in (1 mm) long. Together they cover an area of 2,800 sq ft (260 sq m). Villi give the inside of the intestine a velvety texture, just like a soft towel. They transfer nutrients into the bloodstream.